

(2) Eastern Orthodox (Orthodox Catholic) Church

BRIEF INTRODUCTION

The Eastern Orthodox Church, officially the Orthodox Catholic Church, also known as the Orthodox Church, is one of the three major branches of Christianity with approximately 220-250 million adherents worldwide out of approximately 2 billion (2015 estimates) Christians. Up until the Great Schism in 1054 CE Western (Roman Catholic) and Eastern (Eastern Orthodox) branches, were branches of the same body—the One, Holy, Catholic (Universal) and Apostolic Church.

~~Like the Roman Catholic Church, the Eastern Orthodox Church also claims to be 'the One, Holy, Catholic and Apostolic Church' founded by Jesus Christ through the descent of the Holy Spirit on the Apostles in Jerusalem on the feast of Pentecost. It considers its bishops to be the successors of Christ's Apostles through an unbroken chain. The Church claims to have fully preserved the doctrines, practices and traditions of the early Christian church established by Jesus Christ through the Apostles and thus calling itself to be the only true and 'right (ortho) believing (doxa)' Christian Church.

~~The Eastern Orthodox Church is made up of a number of self-governing Churches which are either autocephalous (self-heading) or autonomous (self-governing to certain extent), with the Ecumenical (universal) Patriarch of Constantinople holding honorary primacy as 'primus inter pares' (the first among equals). It is not a centralized organization headed by a single pope with supreme power. These self-governing Churches are united in faith by a common approach to theology, tradition, and worship defined by the first seven Ecumenical Councils.

~~The Eastern Orthodox Church shares many common beliefs and practices with Roman Catholic Church being part of the One Universal (Catholic) Church until the split (Great Schism) of 1054 CE. They share a common history of first 1000 years of Christianity together. By this time Christianity was in firm footing with most of its doctrine and practices established. The Eastern Orthodox Church only accepts the first seven ecumenical councils which were held (between 325-787 CE) before the schism.

~In our following discussion we will focus only on unique aspects of Eastern Orthodox Church and where there are differences with Roman Catholic Church. So it is important to read upon 'Branches of Christianity' and 'Catholic (Roman) Church' in our website before proceeding any further.

PURPOSE OF LIFE

According Eastern Orthodox Church 'Theosis' is a goal and purpose of life. Theosis also known as deification or divinization, is a concept derived from the Old and New Testament, which teaches human beings can have real union/relationship with Triune God and become like God, a god by Grace. In this process an individual through full cooperation with his faith and actions, joins with God through His uncreated energies (God's Grace), and not through His essence and thus share in the divine nature. This is the mystery of the Orthodox Faith which is often misunderstood by Roman Catholics and Protestants.

CONCEPT OF GOD

Only difference here from Roman Catholic Church, which is also one of the main reasons (known as Filioque Controversy) for the Great Schism in 1054 CE, is that the Holy Spirit is God and the third Person of the Holy Trinity proceeds from the Father (**Roman Catholic has added 'and the Son'**), not made nor created nor begotten but proceeding. So unlike Roman Catholics the Orthodox Christians believe that the Holy Spirit proceeds from God the Father alone.

THE ORTHODOX CREEDS (PROFESSIONS OF THE FAITH)

Like the Roman Catholic the two most important creeds used widely by the Eastern Orthodox Church are 'Nicene Creed' and 'Apostle's Creed'. The Only difference here is an addition (and the Son) by the Roman Catholic Church version of 'Nicene Creed'. This addition was done during the sixth century by some western churches and finally adopted by the Pope of Rome in 1014 CE. The Orthodox Church rejected this addition and stuck to the original version put forward by the first two ecumenical councils (in 325 and 381CE).

The English text of the Nicene Creed: "I believe in one God, the Father almighty, maker of heaven and earth, of all things visible and invisible. I believe in one Lord Jesus Christ, the Only Begotten Son of God, born of the Father before all ages. God from God, Light from Light, true God from true God, begotten, not made, consubstantial with the Father; through him all things were made. For us men and for our salvation he came down from heaven, and by the Holy Spirit was incarnate of the Virgin Mary, and became man. For our sake he was crucified under Pontius Pilate, he suffered death and was buried, and rose again on the third day in accordance with the Scriptures. He ascended into heaven and is seated at the right hand of the Father. He will come again in glory to judge the living and the dead and his kingdom will have no end. I believe in the Holy Spirit, the Lord, the giver of life, who proceeds from the Father (**Roman Catholic has added 'and the Son'**), who with the Father and the Son is worshipped and glorified, who has spoken through the prophets. I believe in one, holy, catholic and apostolic Church. I confess one Baptism for the forgiveness of sins and I look forward to the resurrection of the dead and the life of the world to come. Amen."

SOURCES OF RELIGIOUS/SACRED INFORMATION

Like the Roman Catholic Church the Eastern Orthodox Church also believe in two primary sources of religious/sacred information.

(1) Sacred Tradition (or Holy Tradition).

(2) Sacred Scripture (Holy Bible).

But Eastern Orthodox Church considers Holy Bible as part of Holy Tradition.

(1) Sacred Tradition (or Holy Tradition):

Sacred Tradition is Divine instructions and revelations which were made to the Apostles either orally by Jesus Christ or by the inspiration of the Holy Spirit, some of which were committed to the inspired writings (Sacred Scripture- Bible), and others were transmitted through other means (orally or by practice etc.) by the Apostles to the Church from one generation to the next. Elements of Holy Tradition like the Holy Scriptures, the Creed and the dogmatic and doctrinal definitions of the first seven Ecumenical Councils hold the primary place in Holy Tradition and cannot be (a key difference with Roman Catholic) edited, deleted, revised or altered.

(2) Sacred Scriptures (The Holy Bible):

Most Eastern Orthodox accept that Orthodox Bible is composed of 76 books, 3 books more than the Roman Catholic Bible. There are 49 books which they count as 22 books (because some books are combined) in the Old Testament and 27 books (like other denominations) in the New Testament. Ten out of the 49 books of the old testament are called Deuterocanonical-'second canon' (or Anagignoskomena "readable, worthy to be read") because unlike Roman Catholic those are considered having secondary authority compared to rest of the old testament.

KEY FEATURES OF BELIEF

THE CHURCH

Most important difference with Roman Catholic Church is that it is not a centralized organization headed by a single pope with supreme power. There is no Pope (with supreme power) or equivalent in Eastern Orthodox Church. The Eastern Orthodox Church is made up of a number of self-governing Churches which are either autocephalous (self-heading) or autonomous (self-governing to certain extent).

~~Currently there are fourteen Orthodox autocephalous regional churches that are generally accepted. An autocephalous church is administratively completely independent and has its own authority to resolve all internal affairs on its own. It appoints its own bishops, including the Patriarch, Archbishop or Metropolitan who heads the church. All fourteen autocephalous churches are independent, equal to each other and remain in full sacramental and canonical communion with each other. These autocephalous orthodox regional churches are the four ancient Eastern Patriarchates (Constantinople, Alexandria, Antioch, and Jerusalem), and the ten other orthodox regional churches that have emerged over the centuries in Russia, Serbia, Romania, Bulgaria, Georgia, Cyprus, Greece, Poland, Albania, and the Czech and Slovak Republics. There is a fifteenth autocephalous church, Orthodox Church in America which is only recognized as autocephalous by few of the fourteen regional churches. The autonomous churches are less independent and rely on an autocephalous church for certain functions.

~~An autocephalous regional church has a defined jurisdiction (country or region) and is ruled by its council of bishops or Synod presided by its Primate (First Hierarch or first among equals of all

bishops). The Primate may carry the honorary title of Patriarch, Metropolitan or Archbishop .

~~Eastern Orthodox Church considers Patriarch of Constantinople (Ecumenical Patriarch) as 'primus inter pares ' meaning first among equals. This title is of honor and symbolic unity rather than authority, in fact he does not have any administrative authority to intervene in the affairs of local churches outside his own Patriarchate.

~~The organization of church is both hierarchical and conciliar or synodal. It is considered hierarchical as priests, deacons, and laypersons are expected to follow their bishop who is inheritor of the authority of the apostles, authority given by Jesus. And it is conciliar or synodal as the bishops (all with equal voting power) meet together in synods or councils and reach binding agreements and decisions through consensus.

THE CLERGY

The main difference with Roman Catholic Church here is that Orthodox Church allows married priest (presbyters) and deacons as long as the marriage took place before ordination.

~~Also there is no bishop with supreme power like the Pope of Roman Catholic Church, all bishops are equal, sacramentally none is higher or greater than the other; none rules over other. They do carry different administrative title like patriarch, archbishop, metropolitan or bishop depending on the size, location and importance of their diocese.

~~The other notable distinction is Orthodox clergy are usually bearded whereas Roman Catholic clergy are usually beardless.

MONKS AND NUNS

There are no separate religious orders of Eastern Orthodox monks or nuns like Roman Catholic monks and nuns who belong to a particular religious order such as Rule of St. Augustine or Rule of St. Benedict etc.

~~Orthodox monks and nuns generally do not or less involve in social work or teaching in school. They spent their time in worship, manual labor to support themselves, private prayer, spiritual study, and mediation.

MARY

The only notable difference here with Roman Catholic Church is that Eastern Orthodox Church do not accept the Roman Catholic dogma of the 'Immaculate Conception of Mary' which was a later addition by Roman Pope Pius IX in 1854 CE.

THE SAINTS, ANGELS, FALLEN ANGELS (SATAN and DEMONS)

There is no major difference between Eastern Orthodox and Roman Catholic Church regarding saints, angels and fallen angels (Satan and demons).

THE SACRAMENTS (HOLY MYSTERIES)

The sacraments in the Eastern Orthodox Church are officially called the holy mysteries or sacred mysteries. Like the Roman Catholic Church the Orthodox Church generally accept the seven Sacraments or Mysteries while the Orthodox church do not limit the number to seven or consider it fixed.

Baptism: There is no major difference between Eastern Orthodox and Roman Catholic Church regarding baptism.

Chrismation (Confirmation): Eastern Orthodox Church prefers to use the term Chrismation. In Roman Catholic Church Chrismation (Confirmation) is separated from the Baptism and is performed by the bishop and not the priest but in Orthodox Church is performed with (immediately after) Baptism by a priest who has received "chrism" from the bishop. Unlike Roman Catholic Church, it also performs Chrismation on infants.

The Eucharist (Mystical Supper): The Roman Catholic Church uses unleavened bread for the celebration of the Eucharist, while in the Eastern Orthodox Church only leavened bread is used. The other notable difference would be Roman Catholics believe the consecrated bread and wine changes (a change of the whole substance--though it retains the appearance, odor, and taste of bread and wine) to actual body and blood of Christ through a process call 'transubstantiation' (change of substance) while the Orthodox Christians consider the bread and blood to be changed 'mysteriously' in body and blood of Christ.

Penance (Confession): There is no major difference between Eastern Orthodox and Roman Catholic Church regarding penance.

Matrimony: The major difference here, unlike Roman Catholic, Eastern Orthodox Church allows divorce only in the case of adultery and under extreme exceptional circumstances but condemns the breakdown of marriage as a sin and as evil as it considers marriage (like Roman Catholicism) to be permanent and indissoluble. Remarriage is allowed for widowed spouses and divorced individuals. While remarriage of widowed individuals is seen as a joyful occasion, remarriage (2nd marriage) of divorced individuals are not seen with the same light and includes prayers offering repentance for the earlier divorce.

Holy Orders: The major difference here with Roman Catholic is that Orthodox Church allows ordination of married priests and deacons.

The Anointing of the Sick (Holy Unction): The notable difference with Roman Catholic Church is that, in the Orthodox Church anointing of the Sick is not just for those who are dying or gravely ill, but for all those who are sick.

WORSHIP AND PRAYER

No major significant difference here in terms of belief and concept with Roman Catholic Church. Minor differences exist in language, style, form and other ways which are mostly influenced by local culture and tradition (seen even among different orthodox churches).

~~One notable minor difference here, while many eastern orthodox churches still use old Julian calendar, some other orthodox churches use the revised Julian calendar (which corresponds to Gregorian calendar used by Roman Catholic Church). And for this reason, for an example we see some orthodox Christians celebrate Christmas on December 25th (like Roman Catholic) while others celebrate it on January 7th (which is December 25th in old Julian calendar).

SIN

Eastern Orthodox Church defines sin as the Greek word for sin 'amartia' meaning 'to miss the mark or target'. So, sin is when one pervert what God has given as good, falling short or refusing to follow God's plan and the desire to be "like God". Sin separates one from God, leaving one spiritually dead. For Orthodox Christians, the mark or target is to live according to the teachings and laws of God. And transgression these laws is sin.

~~Unlike Roman Catholics, Orthodox Christians do not categorize sins into mortal and venial sins. They do recognize sins of grave nature for which sacramental penance is necessary. For minor sins there is no necessity of formal penance through sacramental ritual. While it is recommended to go to Confession for sin (regardless of the nature), to the very least one should ask for God's forgiveness whenever it occurs and on regular basis through personal prayers and follow up with Confession on regular intervals.

'Ancestral Sin' not 'Original Sin': Eastern Orthodox Church prefers the term 'ancestral sin' in oppose to the Roman Catholic Church's (and most other denominations) use of the term 'original sin' to refer to the state of humanity after the Fall of Adam and Eve.

~~The Eastern Orthodox Church, unlike the Roman Catholic Church, never speaks of guilt (sin) being passed down from Adam and Eve to humanity. It teaches that humanity inherited only the consequence of Adam and Eve's sin which is death, and not their guilt.

SALVATION

Eastern Orthodox Church teaches (similar to Roman Catholicism) salvation is achieved through faith in Christ (his doctrine, his life, his death, and resurrection) and live accordingly. It teaches that salvation is "faith working through love" an ongoing life long process aiming to obtain 'Theosis' or union with God.

ESCHATOLOGY

Death: Eastern Orthodox Christians believe at death the soul separates from the body. The body returns to the earth to decompose but not lost. The soul lingers on earth for few days (2-3 days). Then soul of the departed ascend to undergo personal trial (particular judgment).

Particular Judgment: Eastern Orthodox Christians believe at particular judgment righteous souls are taken by the angels and brought to the threshold of Paradise, called 'Abraham's bosom', where they remain in a condition of foretasting eternal joy and blessedness waiting for the Last Judgment. And others find themselves in darkness of Hades (foretasting eternal torment) waiting for Last Judgment.

Hades: Hades is the 'abode of the dead' where the soul journeys to after death and remain till Last Judgment. It is not hell as sometimes misunderstood by many. It is spiritual prison for those unrighteous souls that are separated by sin from God. While souls are waiting in Hades the family, friends and faithful on earth can help the unrighteous souls (to cleanse some or all of its sins) by commemoration at the Divine Liturgy, by their prayers, fasts and alms giving on their behalf.

Purgatory: Unlike Roman Catholic Church, Orthodox Church do not accept the concept of Purgatory.

End of time/world and Second Coming of Jesus: No major difference here with Roman Catholic Church.

Resurrection of the Dead: There is no major difference between Eastern Orthodox and Roman Catholic Church regarding resurrection of the dead.

Last (General) Judgment: There is no major difference between Eastern Orthodox and Roman Catholic Church regarding Last Judgment.

Heaven: There is no major difference between Eastern Orthodox and Roman Catholic Church regarding heaven.

Hell: A notable difference with Roman Catholicism is the emphasis on Orthodox Church's teaching that, in hell God does not punish people by some material fire or physical torment but it is the separation from God's glory and love, cause of great trouble and suffering for those who reject God.

The New Heaven and New Earth till eternity: No major difference here with Roman Catholic Church.

INDULGENCE

Unlike Roman Catholic Church there is currently no similar concept of 'indulgence' within Eastern Orthodox Church.

STATUES AND ICONS (IMAGES)

Unlike Roman Catholic Church, Eastern Orthodox Church do not use statues (life like three-dimensional) as it imitates idol worship. It uses Icons (images drawn or engraved) depicting Christ, Holy spirit, Mary, saints, angels and certain events extensively.

SEXUAL MORALITY

There is no major difference between Eastern Orthodox and Roman Catholic Church regarding the teachings about sexual morality.

CONTRACEPTION AND CONCEPTION

Unlike Roman Catholic Church there is no universal position on matter of contraception within the Eastern Orthodox Church. Up until mid twentieth century (around 1960) the Eastern Orthodox position was similar to Roman Catholic Church. But since then a less strict view coming to prevail within some of the eastern orthodox churches. Some Eastern Orthodox theologians and spiritual fathers of current time consider that the responsible use of contraception within marriage is not in itself sinful, hence the use of strictly non-abortive contraceptives are permitted.

ABORTION

There is no major difference between Eastern Orthodox and Roman Catholic Church regarding abortion.

DIVORCE AND REMARRIAGE

Unlike Roman Catholic Church, Eastern Orthodox Church allows divorce only in the case of adultery and under extreme exceptional circumstances. Remarriage is allowed for widowed spouses and divorced individuals.

FOR MORE INFORMATION (Some Sources Used For This Article)

<https://oca.org/orthodoxy/the-orthodox-faith>,
<http://orthodoxinfo.com/general/>,
<http://orthodoxfaith.co.uk/orthodoxy>,
<http://www.greekorthodox.org.au/>,
http://sttikhonsmonastery.org/about_orthodoxy.html,
<http://www.bible.ca/orthodox-church-autocephalous-hierarchy-organization.htm>,
<http://www.orthodoxchristian.info/pages/differences.htm>,
http://www.fatheralexander.org/booklets/english/catechism_ext.htm,
<http://www.orthodoxresource.co.uk/comparative/roman-catholic.htm>,
<http://www.patheos.com/Library/Eastern-Orthodoxy>,
http://www.bbc.co.uk/religion/religions/christianity/subdivisions/easternorthodox_1.shtml.

